

The *automatic* yes

A worksheet on people-pleasing, through
Ferenczi, Winnicott and Gestalt.

A yes that arrives before you do

Some yeses are chosen: you know what you want, you weigh it, you agree. Others arrive first — before you have checked with yourself, sometimes before the other person has finished asking. This worksheet is about the second kind.

It looks at that yes through three lenses from one lineage, then asks you to meet it: slowly on paper, and once in real life.

TIME	About forty minutes in one sitting, or one part a day.
YOU NEED	A pen, and one recent yes you would like to look at more closely.
ANSWERS	Write what is true today. There is nothing to get right.
CARE	If something surfaces with more force than you can hold, stop. Feel your feet on the floor and name five things you can see. Some of this is better explored with a counsellor or therapist than alone.

Three lenses, one lineage

1932

Sándor Ferenczi

Where it begins

Reading another person closely and early, when refusing them is not possible.

Part two

1960

D. W. Winnicott

What it becomes

A caretaker self that protects something more alive underneath.

Part three

1951–1970

Gestalt

How it lives now

At the boundary between you and another person, where it can be noticed, chewed over and met.

Parts one, four and five

Inside

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Catch one yes

Start with something recent and ordinary: a favour, a plan, an extra task, a “sure” that came out before you had thought about it. Stay with the details. They carry the information.

1 What happened? Where were you, who asked, and what for?

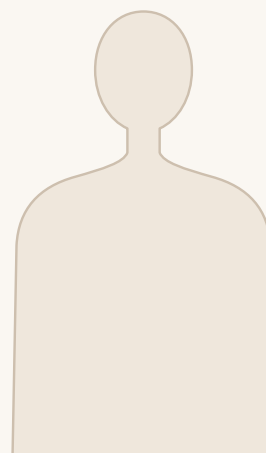
2 What did you sense they wanted — including anything they didn't say?

3 How long between the asking and your yes?

☐ before they had finished ☐ a second or two ☐ after I had thought it over

4 Just before the yes, what happened in your body? Mark it on the figure.

Throat, chest, stomach, jaw, face, breath — whatever you noticed.



5 What did you want, if anything?

A small preference counts.

6 Afterwards, looking at both sides:

What the yes cost

What the yes kept safe

The radar

...subordinate themselves like automata to the will of the aggressor, to divine each one of his desires and to gratify these; completely oblivious of themselves...

SÁNDOR FERENCZI · CONFUSION OF TONGUES BETWEEN ADULTS AND THE CHILD · 1932

Ferenczi was describing children overwhelmed by adults they could not refuse. For them, reading the adult closely was the most intelligent response available: it kept the bond intact, even when the bond was also where the danger came from. A 2025 paper in the *Journal of Trauma & Dissociation* returns to his work and describes this adaptation as what lets an overwhelmed child keep “a bond of tenderness” with the adult.

Your own history may be much quieter. An adult’s temper, fragility, exhaustion or grief can call for the same skill.

1 Whose moods did you learn to read first — and roughly how old were you?

2 What were the early signals?

A tone of voice, footsteps, a silence, the way a door closed.

3 What did reading them early make possible?

- ☐ keeping the peace
 ☐ staying close
 ☐ protecting someone else
 ☐ avoiding punishment
☐ being wanted
☐ _____

4 Where does the radar switch on now? With whom, in which rooms?

5 While it is on, what goes quiet in you?

- ☐ hunger
☐ tiredness
☐ an opinion
☐ anger
☐ a wish to leave
☐ _____

6 It picks up what others miss. Where could you use it by choice, rather than by reflex?

The caretaker

Only the True Self can be creative and only the True Self can feel real.

D. W. WINNICOTT · EGO DISTORTION IN TERMS OF TRUE AND FALSE SELF · 1960

When a baby's spontaneous gestures keep being met with the adult's own instead, Winnicott observed, the baby learns to comply — and compliance slowly becomes a self. He called it the False Self; one of his patients called hers the "Caretaker Self". Its job, he wrote, is "to hide and protect the True Self, whatever that may be." Compliance in itself is not the problem: "the ability to compromise is an achievement." The difficulty begins when the caretaker is the only one who ever answers the door.

1 Write its job description.

Working hours

When and where does it clock in?

Core skills

What is it excellent at?

House rules

What is it never allowed to do?

A day off

If it took one, what might happen?

2 What has it been protecting?

Behind the caretaker: a want, a feeling, a way of being yourself.

3 "The spontaneous gesture is the True Self in action." This week, catch three moments when your body moved first.

A laugh, a reach, a wish to leave, a "no" in the throat.

THE MOMENT

THEN I...

☐ acted on it
 ☐ held it
 ☐ swallowed it

☐ acted on it
 ☐ held it
 ☐ swallowed it

☐ acted on it
 ☐ held it
 ☐ swallowed it

Chew the rule

Ferenczi gave psychoanalysis the word introjection in 1909. Fritz and Laura Perls carried it into Gestalt therapy with a bodily image: an introject is something swallowed whole — a rule taken in before it could be tasted, chewed, and then kept or refused. The automatic yes often rests on one or two of them.

1 Tick any that sound familiar, or add your own.

☐ “Don’t make a fuss.”

☐ “Keep the peace.”

☐ “Their feelings are your job.”

☐ “Needing things is a burden.”

☐ “Be easy to be around.”

☐ “If someone is upset, fix it.”

☐ “Good people don’t disappoint.”

☐ _____

2 Choose one and write it here, word for word.

3 Now chew it, slowly.

Whose voice does it speak in?

When did it make sense — in which situation?

What did it protect, and whom?

What in it is still worth keeping?

What in it no longer fits your life?

4 Rewrite it in your own words, as something you would choose.

For instance, “Keep the peace” might become: “I care about peace, and I can live through some friction on the way to a real one.”

the turn

*Change occurs when one becomes what he is,
not when he tries to become what he is not.*

ARNOLD BEISSER · THE PARADOXICAL THEORY OF CHANGE · 1970

So what follows does not ask you to stop saying yes. It asks you
to be there when you say it.

A yes you are present for is already a different yes.

A pause at the boundary

Gestalt has a name for what the yes once was: a creative adjustment — the best response available in a situation that needed it. The situation has changed; the response stayed. What moves it is contact: being there with your body and your want, while the other person is there too.

1 Feel the pull.

Notice where it lands — perhaps the place you marked on page 3. Say to yourself: there's the pull.

Where it lands for me: _____

2 Buy a breath.

Pick a sentence that makes room, or write your own:

- ☐ "Let me check and come back to you." ☐ "Give me a minute to think." ☐ "I'm not sure yet."
☐ "Can I tell you tomorrow?" ☐ _____

3 Find your part.

What do I want here, even a little? What am I willing to give — all of it, some of it, none of it? Answer from there:

- ☐ yes ☐ partly ☐ not now ☐ no

What I want: _____

What I'm willing to give: _____

A small experiment

Choose one low-stakes moment this week, with someone where a little friction is survivable. The first solution was right for a bond that could not hold a no. The experiment finds out whether this one can.

Where, and with whom: _____

What I'll try:

- ☐ a pause ☐ a partial yes ☐ saying a preference ☐ a small no

If a no has ever been met with threats, punishment or harm in a relationship, the old solution may still be protecting you there. That belongs with support, not with an experiment.

What happened

Fill this in after the experiment, while it is still fresh.

1 What I did:

2 What I felt, and where:

3 What the other person did:

4 What happened between us afterwards — that day, that week:

5 What I learned:

What stays with you

Something I noticed

A rule I'm chewing

The next experiment

The True Self comes from the aliveness of the body tissues and the working of body-functions, including the heart's action and breathing.

D. W. WINNICOTT · 1960



Genia

Gestalt Counsellor · Human Heart

This worksheet goes with the long-form video on people-pleasing on YouTube — [Genia | Human Heart](#).

Sessions online, in English and Russian.

More free material, and a monthly letter: humanheart.life

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